

Dvar Torah Outline — Hoshana Rabbah: Rain, Galut, the Sukkah as “Magen,” and the Two Sealings After Yom Kippur

Abstract

Rabbi Shulman explains that rain during sukkot heightens our awareness of dependence on Hashem and can intensify the lived experience of גלות—sometimes even “שבגלות,” being exiled from the sukkah itself. He develops a framework (rooted in Rav Tzadok and other sources) in which sukkot functions as מגן—not merely “salvation” like Yom Kippur, but protection against slipping back into old patterns. Finally, Rabbi Shulman proposes that Yom Kippur and Hoshana Rabbah represent two distinct “sealings”: one establishing inner identity (who we truly are), and one serving as an external tamper-proof verification that the transformation is real and enduring.

I. Rain on sukkot as an lived exercise in reliance and galut

A. Current reality: rain highlights dependence on Hashem

- Rabbi Shulman opens by noting that rainfall during sukkot places us in a tangible posture of reliance on Hashem, precisely when we are trying to live “outside” in the sukkah.

B. Why sukkot is placed in this season: the Pesiqta and Rav Tzadok

- פסיקתא דרב כהנא: sukkot’s timing connects to the possibility of being “חייב גלות.”
- Rav Tzadok’s read: if Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur passed and the בית המקדש is still not rebuilt, it indicates unfinished spiritual repair, necessitating a push toward deeper reliance through a form of גלות.

C. Emotional/spiritual experience: unsettledness as a feature, not a bug

- Rabbi Shulman describes the disorienting cycle: checking the rain, running out to dry the sukkah, making a blessing, then returning inside when rain resumes.
 - This “not having a מקום” feeling mirrors גלות—lack of settled belonging—and becomes a vehicle for השראת השכינה.
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II. “צא מדירת קבע ושב בדירת עראי”: the point is leaving permanence (3:11)

A. Rav Tzadok's diyyuk in the Gemara's language

- כל שבעת הימים צא מדירת קבע ושב בדירת עראי
- Question: why not simply command “sit in a temporary dwelling”?
- Answer: the emphasis is on **leaving** the mindset of “דירת קבע”—detaching from the illusion that this world is permanent.

B. Worldview shift: this world as an אושפיזא

- Rabbi Shulman cites the idea (Gemara in מועד קטן) that this world is like an inn/hotel—temporary.
- i.e., not defined, עולם הזה becomes possible when a person is not fully “at home” in השראת השכינה by physical permanence.

C. Spiritual mechanism

- As long as one treats עולם הזה as “home,” one becomes “בן עולם הזה,” limiting spiritual receptivity.
 - Treating it as temporary (ירת עראי) opens the person to a relationship with רוחניות and השראת השכינה.
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III. When rain forces you inside: “גלות שבגלות” and a deeper reliance (5:30)

A. Paradox: losing sukkah space may intensify sukkah consciousness

- Rabbi Shulman suggests that being forced out of the sukkah can create a heightened state: “I’m not really supposed to be here (indoors); I’m waiting to go back out.”

B. תנאים for the experience to work spiritually

- If a person “rushes back” into the house with relief—returning to comfort as the default—he may lose the point.
- But if a person remains uncomfortable, longing for the sukkah, feeling displaced, that unsettledness itself can carry a form of השראת השכינה.

C. Clarifying motivations: wanting sukkah for the right reasons

- A discussion emerges: if someone prefers the sukkah because it makes physical indulgence easier, that misses the goal.
- Rabbi Shulman frames sukkot as a structure that helps sanctify physical life—yet demands **יראת שמים** so the sukkah does not become a cover for coarseness.

D. Sukkot as “space” analogous to Shabbat as “time”

- Rabbi Shulman quotes an idea: sukkot in **place** is like Shabbat in **time**—a framework that supports **קדושה** within physical living (meals, enjoyment), while training a person to carry that **קדושה** outward.

IV. Hoshana Rabbah: why the “Yom Kippur” intensity returns (10:07)

A. The experiential question

- Rabbi Shulman highlights the common surprise: Hoshana Rabbah davening feels long and intense, like a return to Yom Kippur—despite being **חול המועד**.

B. The demand to think: the gift of **שכל**

- He stresses that Judaism expects reflection; he frames human intellect as one of Hashem's greatest gifts (after **בחירה**).

C. Rav Tzadok's principle: after geulah comes sukkot

- Rabbi Shulman references the opening teaching in **פרי צדיק**: after a spiritual redemption, there is a **צורך** to “go to sukkot”—a stage that stabilizes and integrates the elevation.

V. “מלך עוזר מושיע ומגן”: mapping the season from Rosh Hashanah to sukkot (12:31)

A. Shiach Yitzchak (Siddur HaGra) on the closing words of “מגן אברהם”

- **מלך** → Rosh Hashanah (coronation/judgment)
- **עוזר** → Aseret Yemei Teshuvah (Hashem “helps” teshuvah; Maharal's linkage of “אלעזר” to “קל” עוזר” is invoked via the story of **רבי אלעזר בן דורדיא**)

- מושיע → Yom Kippur (salvation even when we cannot fully rescue ourselves)

B. Rabbi Shulman's addition: מגן as sukkot

- Sukkot is “magen” in a straightforward sense: the סכך is protective by definition.
 - Key distinction:
 - ישועה: rescue when already in danger
 - מגן: protection preventing the danger from returning
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VI. Why sukkot is “magen”: protecting against relapse into old patterns (15:30)

A. Shem MiShmuel: Yom Kippur atones, but habits remain

- Forgiveness does not automatically undo entrenched behavior and spiritual routines.

B. A vivid image: the יצר הרע returning after being pushed off

- Yom Kippur is like Hashem pulling off the המקטר that is “choking” a person.
- Without continued protection, the person quickly re-enters the same patterns.

C. Sukkot's task

- Sukkot provides a protective environment that helps prevent the immediate return to the same failures—this is the “מגן” stage.
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VII. Two חתימות: identity verification vs tamper-proof sealing (20:02)

A. Two sealings in the tradition

- Rabbi Shulman cites the קדמונים: there is a sealing at נעילה and another sealing at הושענא רבה (the culmination/compression of sukkot).

B. Cryptography analogy

- Rabbi Shulman proposes two distinct functions:
 1. **Identity verification**: establishing the essence—who is speaking / what is real at the core.
 2. **Tamper-proof protection**: ensuring what's inside hasn't been altered after the fact.

C. Applying it to avodat Hashem

- Yom Kippur: like immersion in a mikveh—one moment of total דבִּיקוֹת establishes clarity of identity.
 - Afterwards, the יצר הרע “tampering claim” arises: “It wasn’t real; you were just emotionally moved.”
 - Hoshana Rabbah/sukkot: the external seal that prevents (or refutes) the claim of tampering.
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VIII. National model: Matan Torah and the 40 years as the same two-step seal (25:00)

A. Matan Torah as identity verification

- The revelation is the essential moment where heaven and earth “touch”: the identity of Torah as דבר ה' is established

B. The 40 years in the מדבר as tamper-proof verification

- Rabbi Shulman argues: sustained national life with Torah (learning, acceptance, transmission) blocks claims of later editing or confusion.
- The “bubble” of the desert becomes an external, historical seal against “tampering” narratives.

C. Microcosm in the calendar

- Yom Kippur → inner identity sealing.
 - Sukkot → living under ענני הכבוד imagery for a week as external verification: “this identity can endure in life.”
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IX. בצל, and ענני הכבוד, צלם אלוקים. דמהימנותא (28:00)

A. The Gaon: גילוי שכינה as ענני הכבוד

- Rabbi Shulman emphasizes (citing the Gaon) that ענני הכבוד represent visible revelation of Divine Presence.

B. Ramchal: כבוד ה' as גילוי שכינה expressed in the world

- Where is that expression located? Fundamentally in human beings as צלם אלוקים.

C. After חטא העגל: the logic of הסתלקות and return

- Sin tarnishes צלם אלוקים → natural result is הסתלקות השכינה.
- Teshuvah (completed/ratified on Yom Kippur) restores צלם אלוקים → natural result is return of השראת השכינה / ענני הכבוד.

D. “ושכנתי בתוכם” understood as “within them”

- are invoked: the dwelling is within the people, because (including אור החיים) and others רבי חיים the Shechinah is revealed through their inner spiritual identity.
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X. The סכך “above” and the week that proves we can live this way (32:30)

A. The Sechach as a spiritual “ceiling”

- Rabbi Shulman cites תולדות יעקב (של”ה via): the סכך corresponds to a realm “above” us (a shaping everything beneath it, בינה akin to).
- Living in the sukkah means all actions are “colored” by the sukkah’s spiritual frame.

B. Even indoors during rain: life is still “colored” by the sukkah

- If you feel you’re in the wrong place (indoors), the sukkah remains psychologically/spiritually present.
- That discomfort becomes an opportunity to internalize dependence and vulnerability as part of עבודת ה’.

C. Scaling the week into the year

- Rabbi Shulman frames the week as proof of capacity:
 - If we can live one week with heightened awareness, we can extend it—week to month to year.
 - Sukkot becomes a training ground to move “ספר בינונים” actions into “ספר צדיקים” by infusing physical acts with עבודת ה’.

D. Final formulation: what each stage declares

- **Yom Kippur**: “I am that person” (identity locked in).
 - **Sukkot / Hoshana Rabbah**: “I can live like that” (external seal; prevents the identity from being “lost” or “tampered with”).
 - **Shemini Atzeret**: bringing these lessons back “into the house”—back into ordinary life.
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XI. In Summary

- Rabbi Shulman frames rain on sukkot as a powerful lesson in reliance on Hashem and a lived sense of גלות, potentially even “גלות שבגלות.”
- He develops Rav Tzadok’s point that sukkot’s core is leaving “דירת קבע,” breaking the illusion of permanence so that השראת השכינה can rest on a person.
- He maps the season through “מלך עוזר מושיע ומגן,” defining sukkot as **מגן**—protection against relapse after Yom Kippur’s salvation.
- He proposes two distinct “sealings”: Yom Kippur as inner identity verification, and Hoshana Rabbah/sukkot as the external tamper-proof seal demonstrated by living a week in בצל דמהימנותא.